Three Rhythmical Studies

for piano solo
(2026)

Maychen Liu
(b. 2009)

Program Notes

The first movement, **Contrapuntal Games**, is grounded in sustained, deliberate rhythmic displacement. The left hand sustains a steady pulse of quarter-note triplets, while the right hand articulates regular sixteenth notes, creating a layered texture of colliding rhythmic grids. Toward the conclusion, this mechanistic pattern dissolves as the left hand expands into half notes, suspending temporal momentum.

The second movement, **Shifting Pulse**, structured in two-measure modules, the music alternates unpredictably between 6/8 and 7/8 meters. The right hand presents dense block chords in steady eighth notes, while the left hand traces a syncopated line constructed from dotted rhythms. This constant metric fluctuation imbues the piece with an unstable yet propulsive energy—fractured, yet never relinquishing forward momentum.

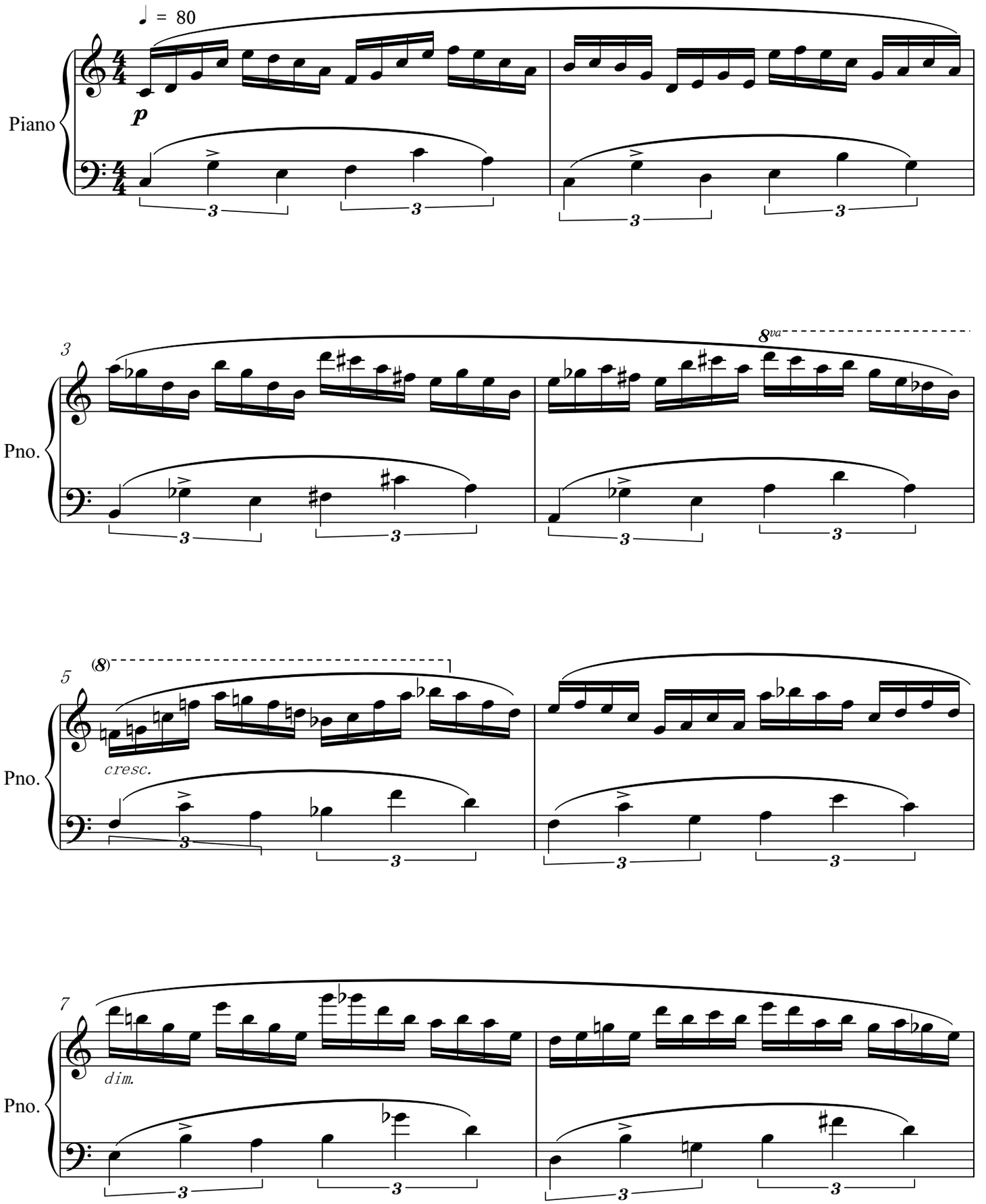
The third movement, **Spatial Diminuendo**, set in a brisk 6/8, this movement traces an arc of approaching and receding sound. A range of motivic figures emerge from a distant plane, gradually intensify, and ultimately fade into silence. The final gesture unfolds via carefully graded dynamics—p, pp, ppp—as the music dissipates into the extreme upper register of the piano.

Duration: ca. 4 minutes 19 seconds

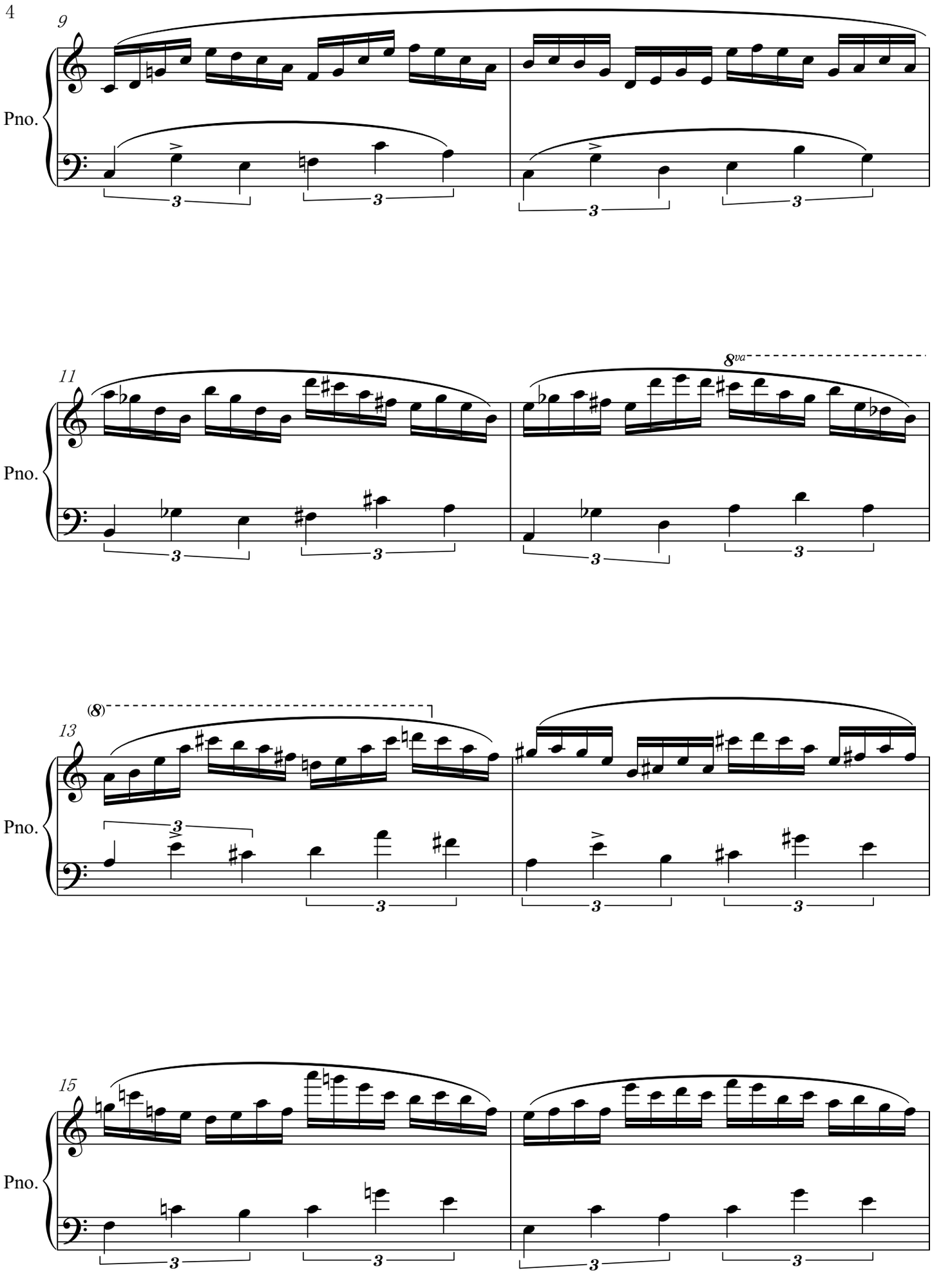
I. Contrapuntal Games

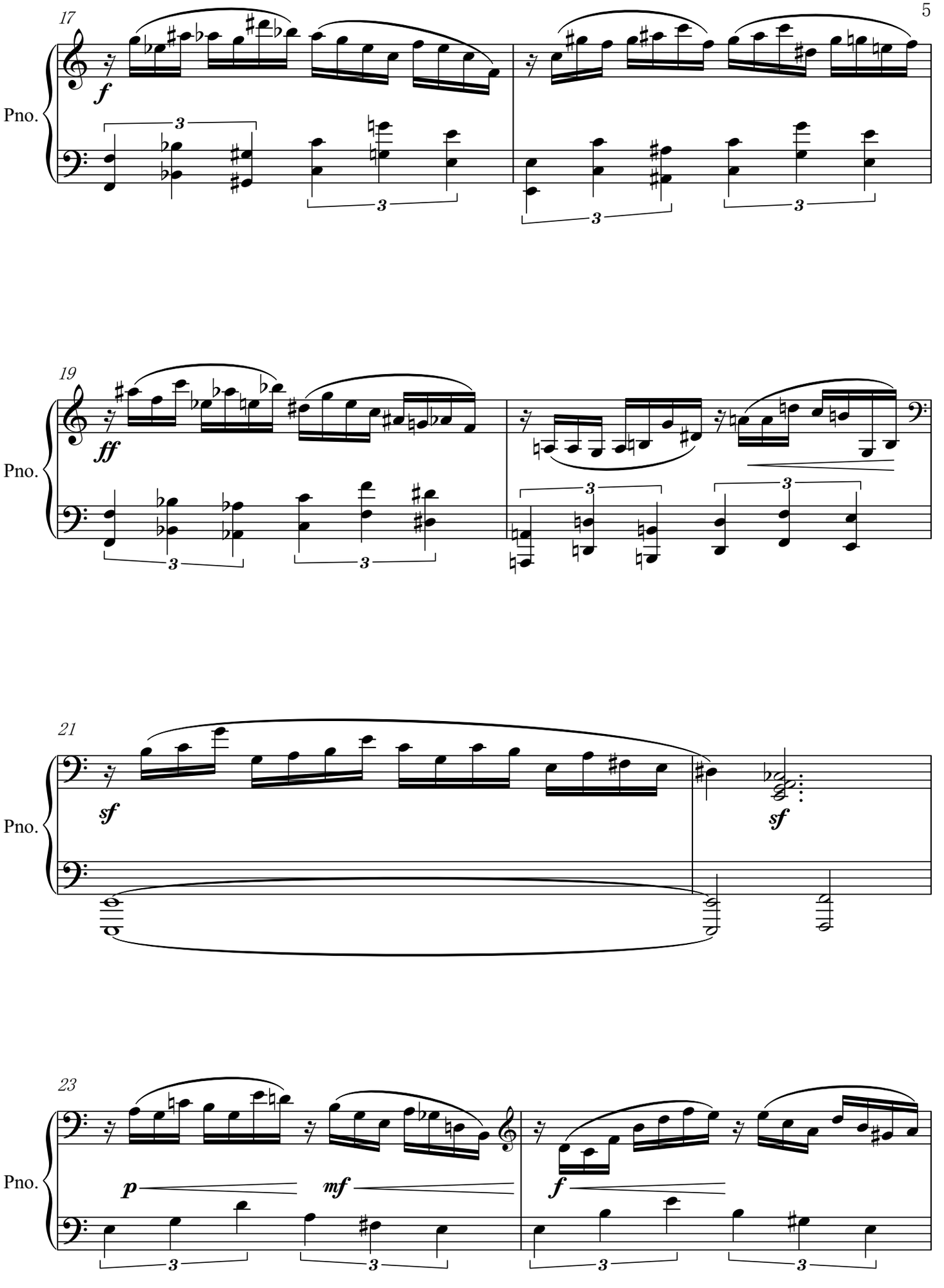
for piano solo
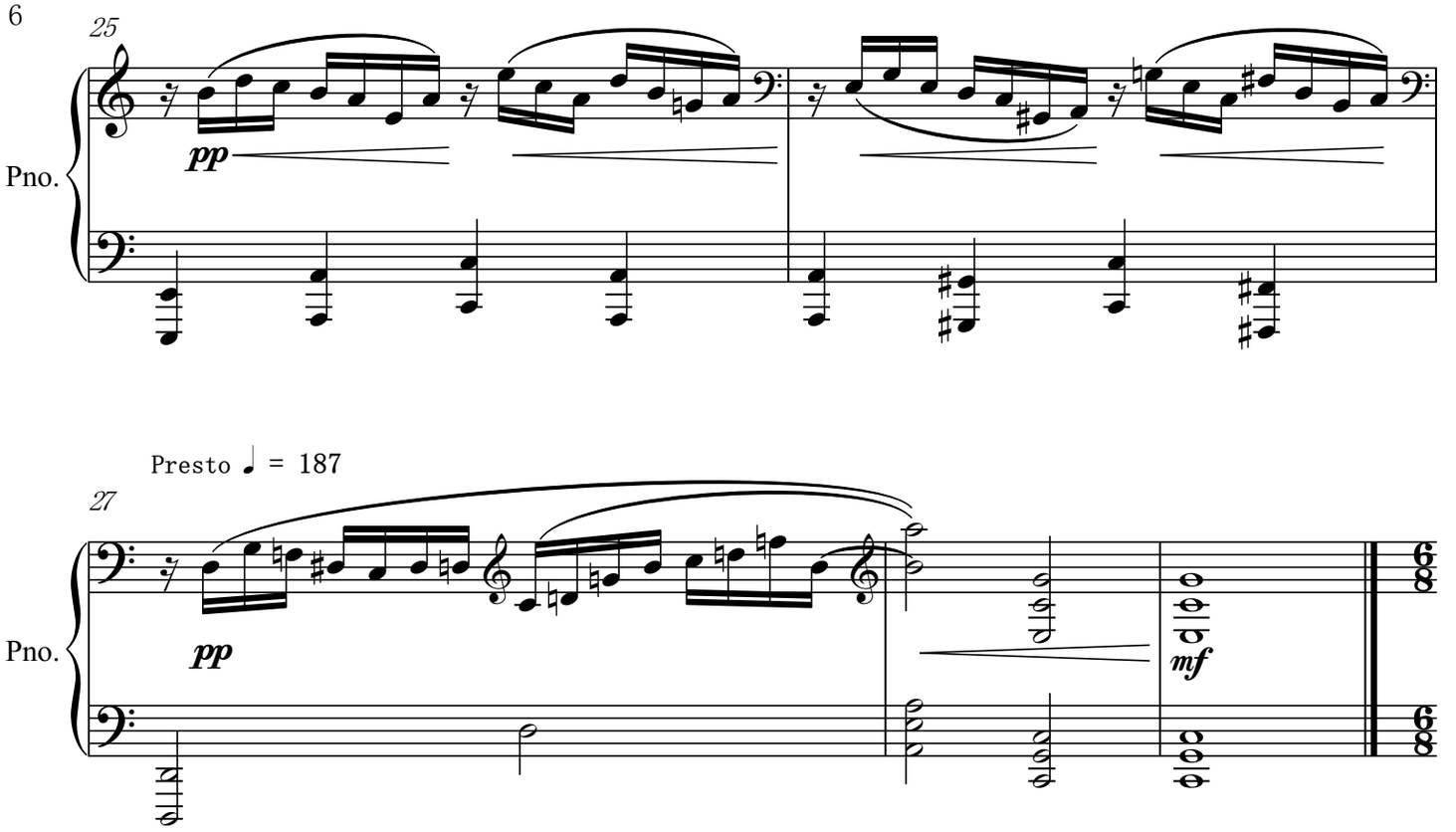
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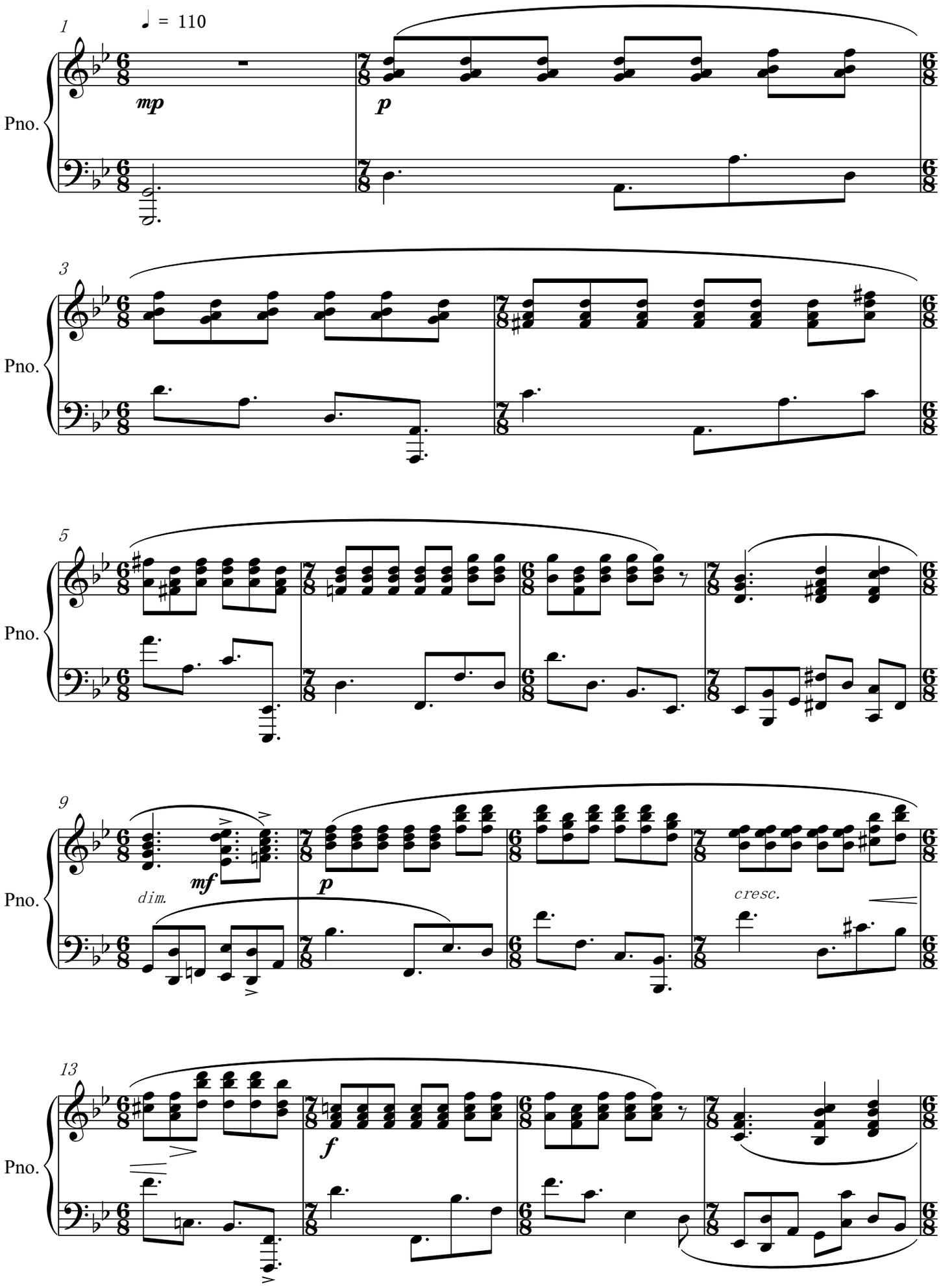

9
Pno.
11
Pno.
8va
(8)
13
Pno.
15
Pno.
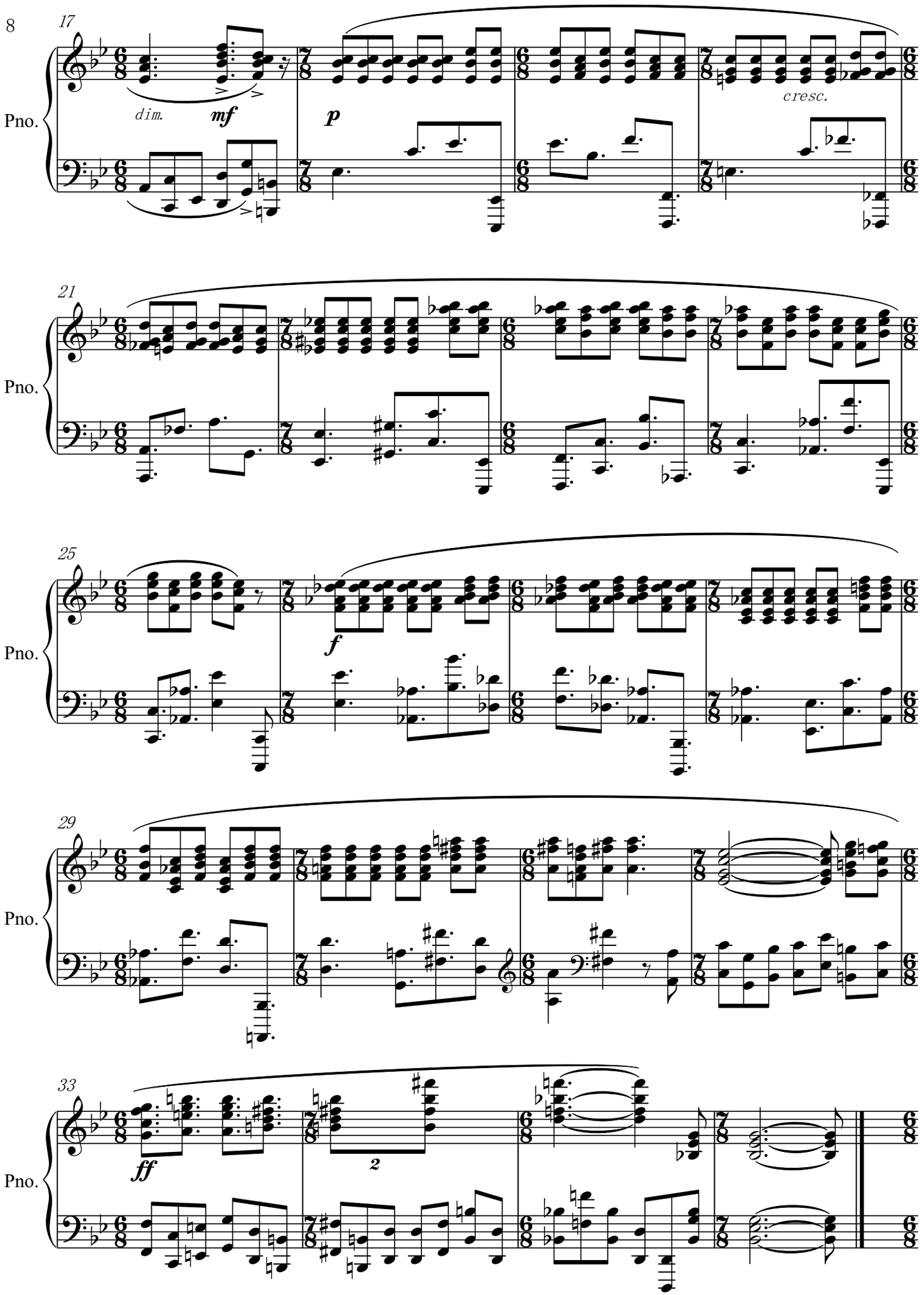

17
Pno.
f
19
Pno.
ff
21
Pno.
sf
sf
23
Pno.
p
mf
f


25
Pno.
pp
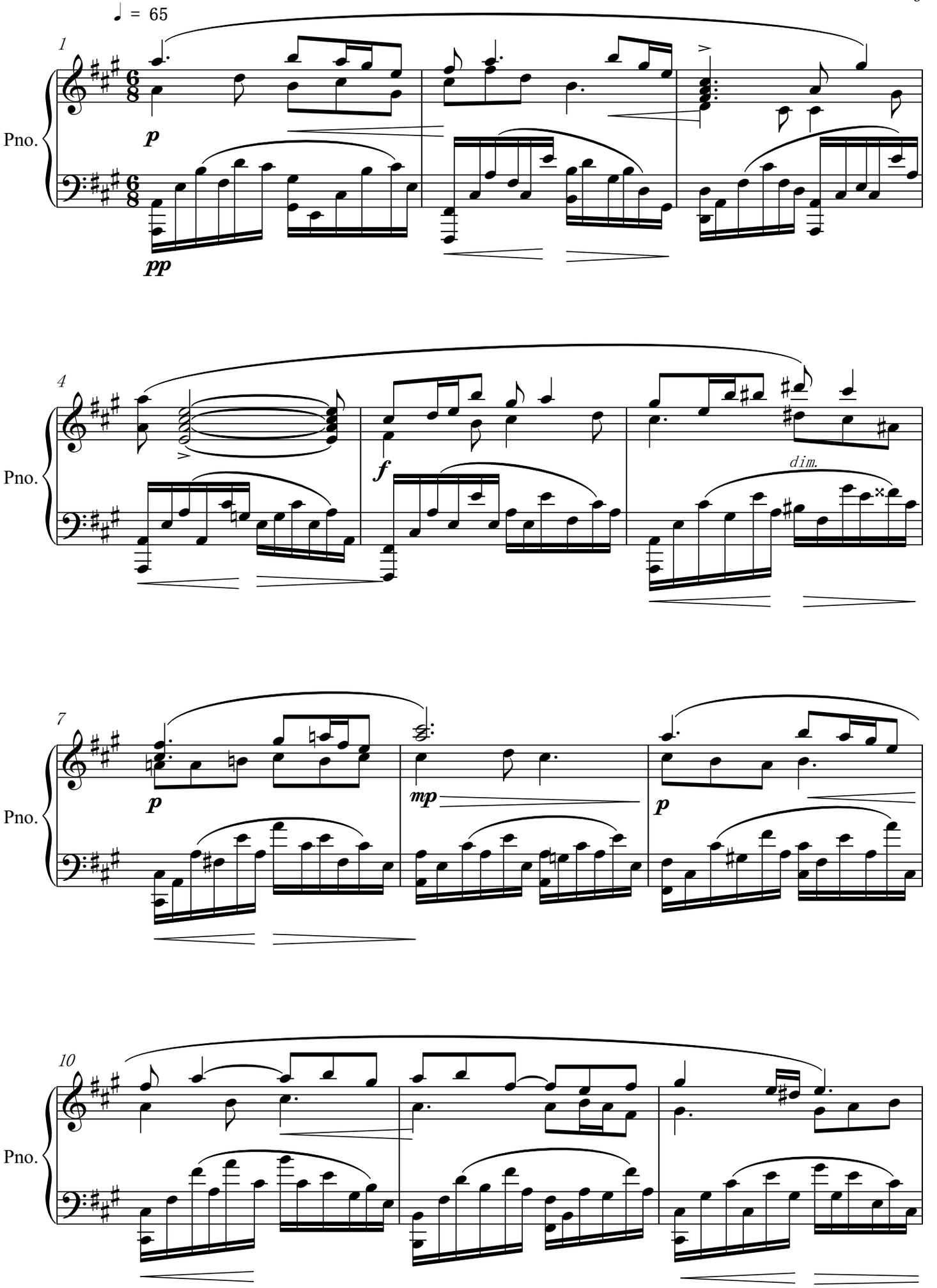
Presto ♩ = 187
27
Pno.
pp
mf
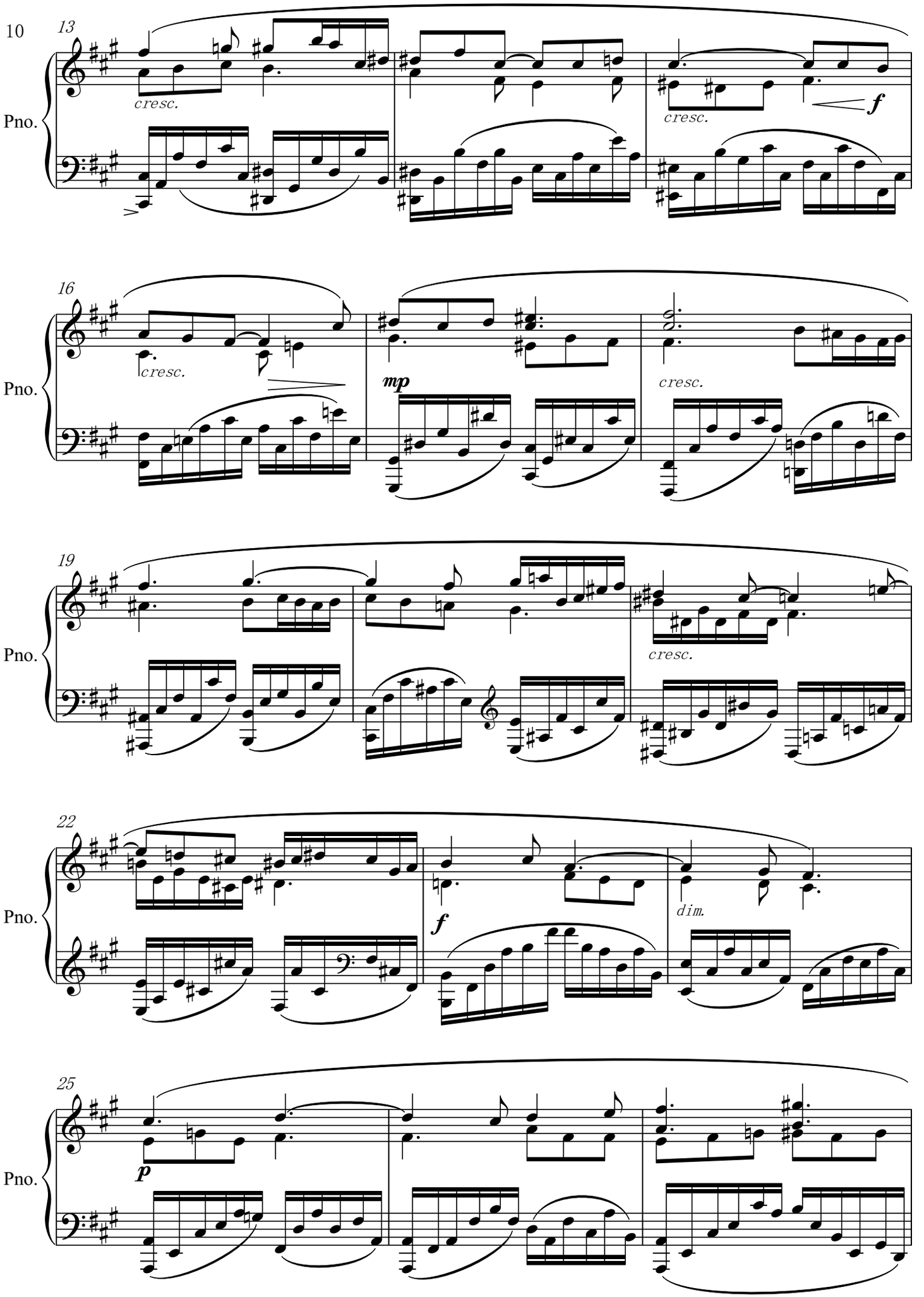
II. Shifting Pulse
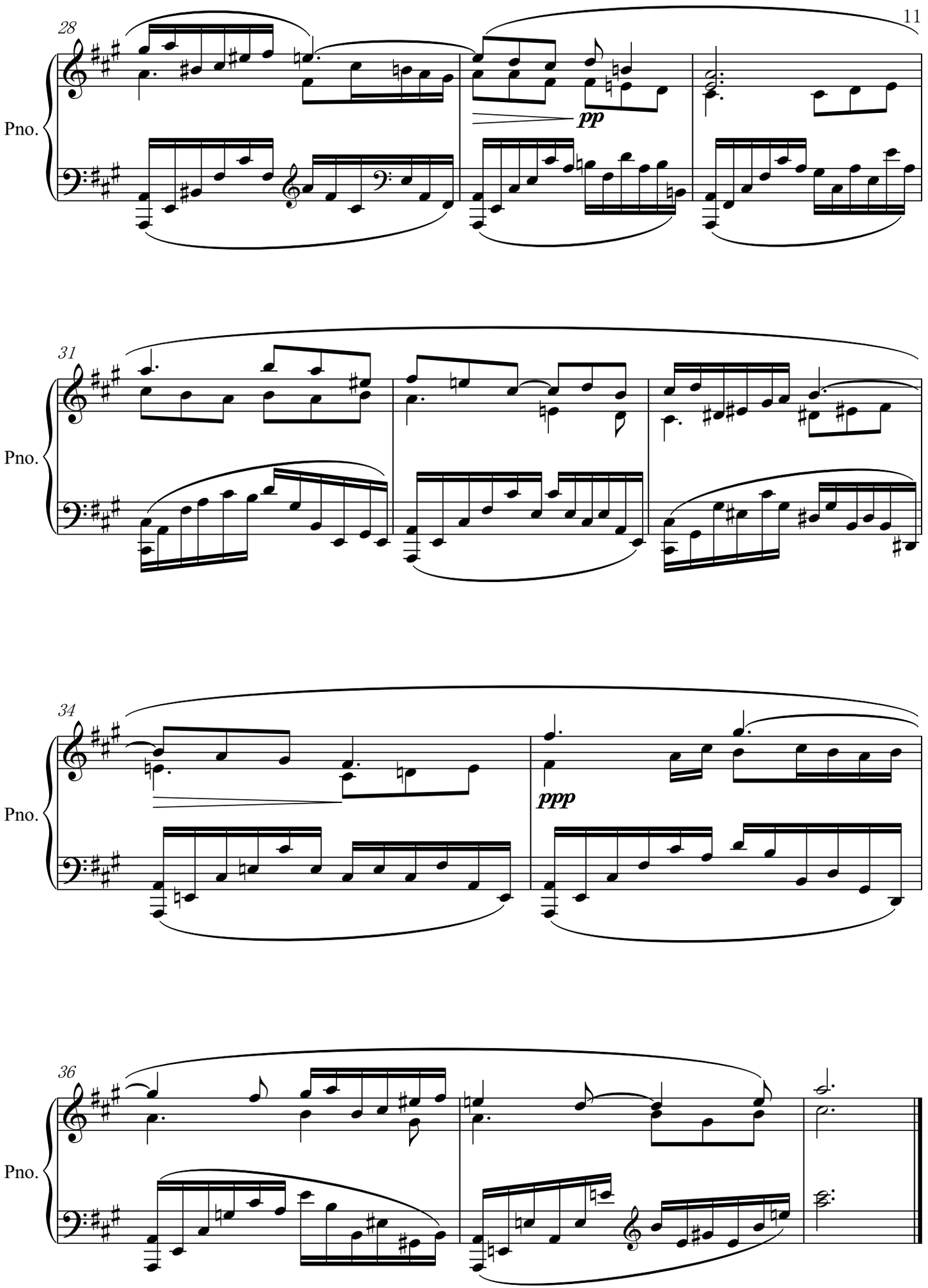



17
Pno.
dim.
mf
p
cresc.
21
Pno.
25
Pno.
f
29
Pno.
33
Pno.
ff
2

III. Spatial Diminuendo




13
Pno.
cresc.
cresc.
f
16
Pno.
cresc.
mp
cresc.
19
Pno.
cresc.
22
Pno.
f
dim.
25
Pno.
p


28
Pno.
pp
31
Pno.
34
Pno.
ppp
36
Pno.